atmosphere, like the air, was heavy. In the intensive care unit of the neurosurgery department, the angel of death roams the halls. And in these surroundings Leika spoke of death, not only as someone who had understood and accepted it, but as someone who had already experienced it.

I sat crouched on the chair at the foot of her bed, my tongue clinging to the roof of my mouth, listening to her words, and not having the faintest idea what I should be saying in such a situation. But Leika did not wait for me to say anything, to ask anything, or to respond to her words. She continued to talk about love, about friends, about Tali and the grandchildren, about saying goodbye, about Kokla, about things that were still left to do—and all of this quietly, almost in a whisper, with a monotonous tone of acceptance, as I shrank further and further into the corner.

I stand here next to her fresh grave and talk about her and to her with the feeling that, with regard to the Shavit family and the relationship between us, she left this world without any doubts.

You were born a princess and grew up to be a queen, and that is how you parted from us, leaving us orphans. We'll miss your one-line reply, "That's me!" whenever anyone dared to comment on your principles or style. Your astuteness was based on rich life experience rather than on a formal education. You had an opinion on every matter, a contribution to make to every conversation, and you knew how to navigate your way through any debate or argument.

In the first twenty years of your life you already had the chance to see the world. You got to know it from the decks of merchant ships that crossed the oceans, as a woman newly married to a seafarer, and as a young mother raising Tali aboard these ships. Already then you were exposed to new landscapes, cultures, and people that expanded your horizons and enriched your life. In those days, we were simple and provincial people whose world more or less finished in Cyprus.

You reached the peak of your self-fulfillment when you tied your life with Kokla's. He opened to you—the young woman of the "high society parlors"—a door to a world that you found fascinating, magical, intoxicating. Paratroopers, Sayeret Matkal, the Mossad, Arik Sharon, Avraham Arnan, heads of the Mossad. A world full of secrets and riddles. Conventional wars, clandestine wars, secret missions. During your time in Paris you also got a taste of the exhilarating feeling of sharing not only in